



CHAPTER ONE

The Borrowed Life



I want to begin with a woman. I will call her Rachel — that was not her name, and I have changed the small details that would give her away, because she trusted me with her life and I intend to keep it safe. But everything that matters about her is true.

It is a little after one in the morning, and Rachel is standing in her kitchen in the dark. She has stood in this kitchen perhaps ten thousand times. She came down for a glass of water and then simply stopped, in the middle of the tile, for no reason she could have named. The dishwasher hums its low, patient hum. On the counter beside her a cup of tea has gone cold and grey; she made it hours ago and forgot it, the way she forgets most things now that are only for her.

She is sixty-one years old. She has raised three children into adulthood. She nursed her own mother through a long dying and closed her mother's eyes with her own hand. She has kept a marriage breathing through twenty-six years that included a bankruptcy, a betrayal, and a long, wordless mending that she and her husband have never once spoken of out loud. She is, by every measure the world knows how to use, a good woman. The one everyone calls when something breaks.

And standing there in the dark, with the water she came for still untouched in the glass, a thought arrives in Rachel that she has been far too busy, for far too many years, to ever let herself think.

Whose life is this?

She does not say it out loud. There is no one to say it to. Her husband has been asleep upstairs for hours, as he usually is by the time she finally comes to bed. So she stands alone in her own kitchen and lets the question move through her like cold water moving through a house at night — quiet, and everywhere at once.

And then Rachel does what she has always done. She pours the forgotten tea down the sink and rinses the cup. She wipes a counter that is already clean. She climbs the stairs, and lies down beside a sleeping man, and tells herself that she is only tired.

But she is not only tired. Somewhere underneath the exhaustion, in a place she has not visited in a very long time, something in Rachel has just woken up — and it is not going to go back to sleep as easily as she hopes.



I have told you Rachel's story first, and not my own theory of your life, for a reason. I do not know your kitchen. I do not know the hour your own version of that thought arrives, or the shape of the life you would be looking at when it does. That is yours, and I would not presume to describe it for you.

But I have sat across from a great many women at the moment just after their own thought arrived. Different countries, different kitchens, different griefs. And I have noticed that nearly all of them do what Rachel did next — they rinse the cup, they wipe the clean counter, they tell themselves they are only tired. And nearly all of them arrive believing the same quiet, terrible thing: that the thought itself is the problem. That a woman who has a good life and still feels the ache underneath it must have something wrong with her.

So if you have ever known a moment even a little like Rachel's, the first thing I want to say to you — before we go anywhere at all — is this. That thought was not ingratitude. It was not the beginning of you falling apart. It was not a betrayal of anyone you love.

It was the first true thing you had let yourself feel in a long time. And I would like to help you follow it all the way home.



I can help you follow it because I did not learn this from a book. I learned it the long way, inside my own life.

I was raised in a home where the holy things belonged to the men. The study, the low music of argument over a single sacred word until midnight, the sense that something enormous and luminous was happening in the next room — all of it went on behind a door I was not invited through. I

was a girl. My work was to carry the tea in and carry the cups out and to be quiet in the space between. As a child I would sit on the floor in the hallway outside that door, in the smell of old coats, and listen until I fell asleep.

And here is what I need you to understand, because it is the whole beginning of this book: I did not experience that door as a cruelty. I did not lie awake resenting it. It never once occurred to me to be angry, because it never once occurred to me that my life could have been arranged any other way. The door was simply the shape of the world. As natural, and as unquestioned, as the sun coming up.

That is what a wall does, my dear, when it is built around a girl early enough. It stops looking like a wall. It starts looking like reality itself.

It took me the better part of thirty years, and a great deal of quiet suffering I mistook for ordinary life, to understand that the smallness I had been calling *humility* was not humility at all. It was something that had been placed on me. And I had worn it so long that I had stopped being able to feel the difference between the covering and my own skin.

Rachel, in her kitchen, was feeling that difference for the first time. So was I, the day I finally understood what my hallway floor had cost me. And if any of this is stirring something in you as you read, then perhaps you are beginning to feel it too. That is not a breakdown. That is the beginning of sight.



There is an old word for the place Rachel was standing in that night — and for the place I lived in for thirty years without knowing it. I want to

give it to you slowly, because we are going to return to it many times before this book is finished.

In Hebrew, the word for Egypt is מִצְרַיִם — MITZRAYIM (Egypt). It grows from the root מִצַּר — MEITZAR (a narrow strait): a tight place, a place with no room to turn around.

For thousands of years, the teachers I love did not read the great story of the exodus from Egypt as history that happened once, to other people, long ago. They read it as something that happens inside a person, again and again, across a life. They understood that each of us has her own MITZRAYIM — her own narrow place — and that the deepest work of a human life is not to arrive somewhere impressive, but simply to walk out of the narrow place she has been living in without ever knowing it was narrow.

And that phrase — *without knowing it was narrow* — is the whole difficulty. Because the first cruelty of the narrow place is that, once you have lived in it long enough, you lose the ability to see that it is narrow at all.

Think of a fish. A fish cannot know it is in water, because it has never known anything else; there is nothing to hold the water up against. And a woman who was handed the walls of her life before she was old enough to choose them does not experience those walls as walls. She experiences them as *the way things are*. As *what a good woman does*. As plain common sense. This is why Rachel could feel the ache so clearly and still have no idea where it came from. The ache was the truest thing in her. But the walls were so close, and so old, and so familiar, that her eye slid right over them — the way, after a while, your ear slides right over the hum of a refrigerator

you long ago stopped hearing. The sound never stopped. She had only stopped being able to hear it.

So before we can loosen a single chain — before we can reclaim one ounce of the life still waiting for a woman like Rachel — there is one quiet, unglamorous, genuinely brave piece of work that has to come first.

We have to make the walls visible again. Because a wall you cannot see is a wall you can never open. But a wall you can finally name has already, in the smallest way, begun to come down.



Now I want to show you what those walls do to the light inside a woman — because this is the teaching I most want you to carry out of this first chapter, and it is the reason I have hope for Rachel, and for you, and for every woman who has ever stood in a dark kitchen wondering whose life she is living.

Kabbalah has a name for the coverings that hide a woman's light. They are called the קליפות — KLIPOT (shells, or husks). The singular is קליפה — KLIPAH (a shell).

Picture an almond resting in your open hand. Inside is the pale, living fruit — the part that can be planted, the part that can feed you, the part that is the entire point of the almond. But around that fruit there is a hard shell, and around the shell, when it first falls from the tree, a bitter green husk. The husk is not the almond. It never was. In its own rough way it once protected the almond as it fell — but if that husk is never opened, the fruit inside simply stays buried. Season after season. Whole, and alive, and completely unseen.

This is the teaching, and it is the hinge on which everything else turns. Inside every woman there is a spark — a נִיצוֹץ, a NITZOTZ (spark) of endless light. It cannot be broken. It cannot be stolen. It cannot be diminished by anything that was ever done to her, or by anything she failed to do. But it can be *covered*. Shell over shell over shell. Until a woman can no longer feel the warmth of it, and slowly, without ever once deciding to, comes to believe it was never there at all.

This is what had happened to Rachel. Not the loss of her light — the *covering* of it. And it is why her tears, when they finally came, were not the sound of something breaking. They were the sound of something buried beginning to stir. Here is the truth I gave to Rachel that afternoon, and the one I most want to give to you now:

You are not the shell. You are the spark inside it.

The exhaustion is not you. The endless usefulness is not you. The smallness a woman can practice for so many years that it begins to feel like virtue — that is not her, and it was never her. These are shells. And a shell, however thick, however many winters it has been closing over the light, was never meant to be permanent. It can be opened. That is the entire promise of this book: not that we will make you into someone new, but that, one husk at a time, we will uncover the woman who was there all along.



Which brings us to the question Rachel asked me next, once she had dried her face. If the shells are not who we are — where do they come from?

Some of them, it is true, we grow ourselves, over the years, to survive things we should never have had to survive. A girl punished for her anger learns to grow a shell over it. A girl shamed for her hunger learns to grow a shell over her wanting. We will tend to those shells, gently, further on.

But so many of the shells a woman carries — far more than she would ever guess — she did not grow at all. She inherited them. They were placed on her before she could speak, by people who were themselves only handing down the shells that had been placed on them, who received them in turn from people who had no idea they were passing anything down at all. I have come to call these the *borrowed beliefs*: the rules a woman lives by that she never once sat down and chose.

When Rachel and I went looking for hers, we found them quickly, because they were the same ones I hear in kitchen after kitchen, in a dozen languages, spoken as though they were simple facts about the world:

A good woman puts herself last.

Wanting more is ungrateful.

If you rest, something will fall apart — and it will be your fault.

Your worth is what you provide.

Love means never letting anyone see what it costs you.

It is too late to change now. You have made your bed.

Rachel had never chosen a single one of these. She had never, at some clear moment in her girlhood, weighed them in her two hands and decided they were true. They were the water she swam in. They came to her in the voice of a mother who loved her and was drowning in her own narrow place;

and from a grandmother, and a tradition, and a whole wide world that had decided what a woman was for long before Rachel arrived to disagree.

This is what I mean by the borrowed life. A life lived faithfully — often beautifully, often with enormous love — inside walls a woman never once agreed to.

And I want to be very careful here, because this is the exact place where a woman is tempted to turn on herself. When Rachel first saw her borrowed beliefs laid out plainly, her face did something I have watched a hundred times. It crumpled, not with grief this time, but with shame. *How did I not see it*, she said. *How did I give away thirty years to a rule I never even chose. What a fool.*

I took her hand, and I will say to you now what I said to her then. You were not a fool. You were a girl who was loved into a shape — and that is not the same thing as being weak, and it is not the same thing as being blind. A fish is not stupid for failing to question water. No woman can be blamed for not seeing a wall that every single person around her had agreed, her whole life long, to call the sky. The seeing was not available to her before. It is available now. That is not a reason for shame. That is the beginning of freedom.

*You did not lose yourself all at once. You gave
yourself away slowly — in a thousand small acts
of love.*



I have told you about Rachel, whose narrow place became visible to her at sixty-one, in the wreckage of a long and openly difficult life. But I do not want you to imagine that this only happens to the Rachels — only on the far side of the raising and the nursing and the burying. So let me tell you, more briefly, about another woman, because her narrow place was quieter, and in some ways crueller, precisely because it left no marks.

I will call her Dina. She was fifty-two, and by every outward sign her life was not ending but flourishing. She was married to a genuinely kind man who had done nothing wrong. Her children were grown and well. She had work she was good at. There was no crisis anyone could point to, no betrayal, no visible wound — and that, she told me, was the loneliest part of all. Because a woman with a kind husband and healthy children and good work is not permitted to be unhappy. There is no room in that story for her ache. So Dina had done what such women learn to do. She had swallowed it, and smiled, and quietly called herself ungrateful for even feeling it.

Dina's borrowed belief was a single sentence, and she had been obeying it so long she had never once heard it as a sentence at all: *love means never letting anyone see what it costs you*. Somewhere very young she had learned that her needs were a weight other people should not have to carry, and so she had spent three decades becoming the most effortless woman anyone knew. She never asked for much. She never made a fuss. She was, everyone agreed, so easy to love.

And she was disappearing so gradually, and so politely, that no one — not even the kind man who shared her bed — had noticed there was a woman quietly going missing in that house.

I tell you about Dina so that you will not disqualify yourself from this book. You do not need a catastrophe to have earned the right to this work. You do not need your marriage to be unhappy, or your life to be visibly broken. The invisible chains are the entire point. A borrowed belief rarely announces itself; it prefers to hide inside a woman's virtues. It wears the mask of being *good*, and *easy*, and *strong*, and, above all, *fine*. If you are the woman everyone leans on, the one who is always fine — I would gently ask you to keep reading with particular care. This book was written for the Rachels. But it was written, most of all, for the ones who never let it show.



It is possible that, somewhere in the last few pages, a small and certain voice has risen up in you. A voice that says: *this is self-indulgent. Other women have real problems. Who am I to sit here examining my little rules like a woman with nothing better to do.*

If that voice has spoken, I want you to notice it — because I have something important to tell you about it. That voice is not your conscience. That voice is the shell, defending itself.

A wall does not wish to be seen. The entire survival of a borrowed belief depends on its never being lifted into the light and questioned. So the moment a woman begins, in earnest, to look, the walls begin to whisper that the looking is selfish, foolish, dangerous, far too late, not for a woman like her. Rachel heard that voice. I heard it for years. You may be hearing it right now. It is not a sign that you are doing something wrong. It is a sign that you have begun to do exactly the right thing — and that something inside you knows it, and is afraid.

Seeing is not self-indulgence, my dear. Seeing is the bravest act available to a woman in a narrow place. Anyone can stay asleep. It takes real courage to wake up inside your own life and admit that some of it was never yours.



Let me be very clear about what this brave looking does, and does not, ask of you — because I have watched too many women handed a reckless and lazy version of freedom, and be harmed by it.

It does not ask you to burn your life down.

Somewhere along the way, the world began selling women the idea that freedom means the grand gesture: the door slammed, the marriage ended, the whole existing life set alight so that something truer might rise from the ashes. Sometimes an ending is right, and necessary, and when we come to such a moment I will speak of it with all the seriousness it deserves. But the notion that liberation *requires* destruction is not wisdom. It is only another way of losing yourself, louder this time, and it has left a great many women more lost than they began.

What Rachel did was quieter than that, and far braver. She did not leave anything, that first year. She simply began to *look*. She took each rule she lived by and held it up to the light and asked it a single question — the one question almost no one had ever taught her she was allowed to ask:

Did I choose this — or did I only inherit it?

She threw nothing away. She changed no fact of her life that season. She only learned, slowly, the true shape of the room she had been standing in for forty years. And I promise you, from watching it happen in real women in real kitchens: the moment a woman can name a wall as a wall, a

thin bright line of light comes through the exact place where the naming happened. And light, once it has found even the smallest crack, has a very old habit of widening it.

Naming the shell is the first way of opening it.

I will not leave you wondering what became of Rachel — not fully, not yet, because her story runs quietly through this whole book. But I will tell you this much now, so that you will believe, on the very first page of your own turning, that the far edge of this exists. It was not quick. Her changing took the better part of two years, and it was not tidy, and more than once she was sure she had made a terrible mistake in ever letting herself ask the question at all. But two years after that night in the dark kitchen, an envelope reached me, and inside it was a photograph: Rachel, standing alone on a stone terrace somewhere near the sea, the wind lifting her grey hair off her shoulders, a small cup of coffee in her hand, squinting into a light that was very plainly not the light of her old kitchen. On the back, in a hand shaking with joy, she had written seven words.

I asked the question. Then I answered it.

She was still, that night in the dark, exactly the woman she would become on that terrace. She simply could not see it yet, because she had not yet learned to see the walls. That is where we begin. Not with the terrace. With the walls.

A R I T U A L

Naming the Borrowed

You will need only ten quiet minutes, a single sheet of paper, and a pen that feels good in your hand. If you have a candle, light it — not because the candle holds any power, but because a small living flame has a way of telling the mind that this ordinary moment is about to become a sacred one.

Draw one line down the middle of the page. On the left side, write a single heading: *The rules I live by.*

Now let them come — every *should* you can feel in your body. *A good mother should. A good wife should. A woman my age should. I should always. I should never.* Do not edit them. Do not make them reasonable. Do not soften them into something you would be comfortable saying aloud at a dinner table. Write the raw ones, the ones that live low in your stomach, the ones that tighten the back of your neck. Let the page fill.

When no more will come, return to the top. Beside each rule, on the right side of your line, write one word only. *Chosen.* Or *Borrowed.* Do not agonize; your body already knows. The chosen ones tend to feel like standing on your own two feet. The borrowed ones tend to feel like a hand pressing gently, and endlessly, on the back of your neck.

Do not fix a single thing tonight. Do not tear up one rule. This is not yet the chapter where you set anything free — that comes later, and slower, and with far more tenderness than force.

Tonight you are doing only the one thing that makes all the rest of it possible. You are turning on the light in a room you have been living in blind.

A QUESTION TO CARRY

Before You Turn the Page

*“Which of the rules I live by did I truly choose —
and which did I simply inherit?”*

There is no need to answer it today. Let it walk beside you through the ordinary hours — the driving, the dishes, the waiting rooms. Let the answer arrive the way real answers arrive: slowly, sideways, when you have stopped staring straight at them.

And do not rush her. The נֶשָׁמָה — the NESHAMAH (soul) — does not speak when she is being interrogated. She speaks in the quiet, to a woman who has finally stopped long enough to listen.

— Ora

Rachel rinsed her cup that night and went to bed believing something was wrong with her. It would be some time before she understood that

nothing was wrong with her at all — that she was only a woman beginning, at last, to see the walls.

But seeing the walls uncovers something else, right on its heels — something it did in Rachel, and something it may already be doing in you. Because it is one thing to discover that you have been living by rules you never chose. It is a heavier thing by far to face the feeling that has been waiting all along underneath them: the quiet, lifelong suspicion that the problem was never really the rules.

That the problem was *her*. That there had always been something a little wrong with her — something that needed managing, something to be apologized for or earned down, before she would ever be permitted to want more.

That feeling has a name. It was handed to her exactly the way the rules were handed to her. It is the heaviest shell of them all, and the oldest, and the one that has cost her the most.

In the next chapter, we are going to lift it off her. And, if you will let me, off you.